Wizardry — operator plan

Written 12 November 2026, against the live instance at `wizardry.slothlee.xyz` on Fluxer release 2026.1112.20122. Every number below was measured on that instance; the command that produced it is named beside it.

This is a plan for running and finishing a **private, self-hosted instance**, not for forking a chat platform. Wizardry is a fork of Fluxer, and the fork's job is to carry the name, the seal and the desktop build — not to re-implement messaging. Anything the upstream does well is left alone.

1. Facts

Fact	Value	How known
Release	Fluxer `2026.1112.20122`	`rexctl status`
Host	4 vCPU / 8 GB, 11 GB of 75 GB used, 1 GB RAM in use	`df -h /`, `free -g`
Accounts	2 (tibs, eleven)	`count(*)` on `users` in the KV store
Guilds	1 — "ooo aa up the ra", no icon	`guilds` row
Channels / messages / attachments	9 / 8 / 5	`count(*)` per table
Guild members	2	`guild_members`
Store size	349 rows, 616 kB	`pg_total_relation_size('fluxer_kv')`
Registration	**open**, no allowed domains, admin URLs enabled	`registration_config`
Instance notice	none	`instance_notice` absent
Community / billing config	none / none	`instance_configuration`
Backups	**1** (manual, today, 2.2 MB), **0 scheduled jobs**	`/opt/fluxer/backups`, `crontab -l`, `systemctl list-timers`
Auto-upgrade	off	`rexctl auto-upgrade`
Email	SMTP `smtp.slothlee.xyz:25` STARTTLS, `noreply@slothlee.xyz`	`instance_integrations_config`
TLS	valid to 10 Feb 2027	`openssl s_client`
DNS	A `78.47.152.93`, **no AAAA**	`dig` via 1.1.1.1
Branding	name, seal, favicons, theme `#1b1330`, custom CSS — live	discovery document and served HTML
Operator tooling in the fork	none — no `scripts/` directory	`ls`

Two numbers decide the shape of this plan: **2 accounts, 8 messages**. Nothing here needs a feature that scales. Everything here needs to survive the owner forgetting about it.

2. The questions worth answering

Each feature below answers a question an operator asks out loud. Nothing is on this list because it would be impressive.

#	Question	Evidence of absence or gap	Kind
1	"Can anyone just walk in?"	`registration.mode = open`, `allowed_email_domains: []`	finding
2	"Can I get it back if it breaks?"	1 manual backup, 0 scheduled jobs, never restored once	finding
3	"Did that change do what I think it did?"	no gate; today every branding change was verified by hand, six checks per restart	finding
4	"Can I change the instance without hand-writing JSON?"	three bespoke KV scripts written and run today; repo carries no operator tooling	finding
5	"What does someone see on day one?"	no notice, no pinned welcome, 8 messages across 9 channels	finding
6	"Does it look like Wizardry everywhere the name appears?"	guild has no icon or banner; `BANNER`, `INVITE_SPLASH`, `ANIMATED_ICON` are enabled and unused	finding

3. The six features

3.1 Invite-only front door

Phase 1 · protects the instance

Turn registration from open to invite-only, and keep the invite card on-brand so an invited person's first impression is the seal rather than a generic join page.

- Rules: the instance refuses self-signup; an invite is the only door; an expired invite says so in words, never in an error code. Existing accounts keep working.
- Pass: `POST /api/v1/auth/register` returns the closed registration error; one invite link still creates an account end to end; the invite page renders the seal at 390 px wide with no broken image.
- Decision needed: open to `@slothlee.xyz` only, or strictly invites? (see §7)

3.2 A backup that runs without me

Phase 1 · protects the instance

Nightly snapshot, weekly verification, and one restore drilled for real.

- Rules: a failed backup is louder than a successful one; the drill restores into a scratch folder, never over the live store; retention keeps three (current setting).
- Pass: seven consecutive nightly archives with zero failures, each passing `rexctl backup verify`; one documented restore of today's archive with the wall-clock time it took; the oldest archive ages out on schedule rather than on a hunch.

3.3 Restart gate

Phase 2 · proves the instance

One command that answers "is Wizardry still Wizardry" after any restart, deploy or `rexctl upgrade`.

- Checks: `rexctl doctor`; `/`, `/.well-known/fluxer`, `/app`, `/admin` status codes; branding present in the served HTML (name, theme colour, both favicons, custom CSS block); the sign-in page rendered in headless Chromium with the mark loaded and the primary button's label colour not equal to its fill; the discovery document agreeing with the branding row.
- Rules: it fails on a missing asset, not only on a non-200; it never writes anything; a check it cannot compute reports as a warning with the reason, never as a pass.
- Pass: one command, exit 0 only when all eight checks pass; proven by breaking one thing on purpose (wrong favicon URL) and watching it fail.

3.4 Operator CLI

Phase 2 · proves the instance

The three operations I hand-wrote today — apply branding, transfer guild ownership, append an audit entry — as checked commands with `--dry-run`.

- Rules: every command prints the diff it would make before making it; the audit entry is written by the tool, not remembered by the operator; no command invents a value it was not given; re-running is idempotent.
- Pass: three commands (`brand`, `own`, `audit`), each with a dry run, each re-runnable with zero diff on the second pass; the KV rows they write match what the client reads.

3.5 A welcome that isn't blank

Phase 3 · presents the instance

A first-run notice and one pinned message, in the voice the brand already uses.

- Rules: no feature tour, no carousel, no "getting started" checklist — one notice, one pinned message, three lines each; it says what the instance is for and how to get an invite.
- Pass: a test account's first screen shows the notice; the pinned message is the first thing in `#general`; both read correctly at 390 px and in the desktop client.

3.6 Identity surfaces finished

Phase 3 · presents the instance

Guild icon, banner and invite splash from the same seal, so the name appears nowhere as a placeholder.

- Rules: same palette as `brand/BRAND.md`, no second mark, no mascot; art is generated from the HTML sources in `brand/`, not drawn anew.
- Pass: guild icon 512×512, banner 960×540, splash 1920×1080, all rendering in the client; the invite card and the guild header both show the seal; zero default-art placeholders left.

4. Order, and what would change it

1. **Backup that runs without me** (3.2) — the only item whose absence can destroy the other five.

2. **Invite-only front door** (3.1) — cheap, and it closes a door that is currently open to the internet.
3. **Restart gate** (3.3) — every later change depends on being able to prove it.
4. **Operator CLI** (3.4) — pays for itself the second time branding changes.
5. **Identity surfaces** (3.6) — visible, but nothing is broken without it.
6. **Welcome** (3.5) — last, because its content depends on who is being welcomed.

If only one thing is built: **3.2**, and specifically the restore drill. A backup that has never been restored is a rumour.

5. Considered and rejected

- **Forking the API to add messaging features.** The fork exists to carry identity and the desktop build. Every feature above is operator-level; none touches the Rust tree.
- **Turning on premium/billing.** `instance_billing_config` is absent and premium is off. Selling to two accounts is a support burden with no upside.
- **Message search tuning.** Eight messages. Meilisearch is running and unbothered.
- **Voice quality work.** LiveKit reports healthy and `rexctl doctor` agrees; there is nobody on the other end of a call yet.
- **Custom badges, themes marketplace, multiple palettes.** `BRAND.md` says one accent, and badges need someone who wants one. Both are answers to a question nobody asked.
- **An AI agent in the guild that writes records.** It would put a model's words where a person's belong; the plan keeps authorship human.
- **Fixing the mail server's "everything is encrypted" symptom in this document.** It is a different product, and it still needs one screenshot to diagnose.

6. Correction

Earlier in this arc I read "the reset link says 404" as a Wizardry routing problem and spent effort on the app's `/reset` route. The link was the **mail server's** recovery email, which built its URL from the mail domain — so it pointed at the brochure site, which has no reset page. Fixed in that server's `send_recovery`, rebuilt and deployed; the app's `/reset` was never broken. Recording it here so the next session does not re-derive the wrong fix.

7. Open questions for the owner

1. Signup: invites only, or open to `@slothlee.xyz` addresses? (Both are one setting.)
2. Who else is joining, and roughly when? Phase 3 exists for them, not for you.
3. Is the guild staying "ooo aa up the ra" with no icon, or should it carry the seal?
4. IPv6: add the AAAA record yourself, or hand me a Cloudflare token to do it?

8. What would falsify this plan

If ninety days pass with **two accounts and no new member**, phases 2 and 3 are decoration: the instance is a private tool, and the honest plan collapses to §3.2 plus §3.1, with everything else struck.

The plan should then be re-issued shorter rather than defended.

Change log

- 12 Nov 2026 — first issue. Measured against the live instance; branding already shipped, so it is not a feature here, it is a fact.